Algorithmic Futures Trading Plan

Business report: strategy, funding model, roadmap and risk

NQ / MNQ and MCL futures | MultiCharts automation | Apex Trader Funding

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In one sentence

Use prop-firm accounts as a low-cost live test bench and funding source for a diversified, backtested set of automated futures strategies; scale to Apex's 20-account limit once the edge is confirmed live, and channel payouts into a personal trading account where proven strategies can grow without payout caps.

All performance figures are backtests (2018-2026) and simulations, not guarantees. Live results are expected to be lower.

1. Executive summary

The business runs a portfolio of eight automated futures strategies on proprietary-trading ("prop") accounts at Apex Trader Funding. Prop accounts let us trade with the firm's capital: our only cost is the evaluation and activation fees, while profits are paid out up to a fixed cap per account. The plan has three stages: **prove** the edge live on a few accounts, **scale** to Apex's 20-account limit, and **compound** payouts in a personal account that has no payout cap.

Key figure	Value	What it means
Strategy edge (backtest, 1 NQ each)	~$101k / year, Sharpe 2.75	Max drawdown $24k; 19% of months lose money
Share of profit that is real skill	92% (alpha t-stat 7.1)	Only 8% comes from simply being long NQ
Evaluation pass rate	50% (50K) / 42% (150K)	Zero-skill baseline is ~40%
Payout per funded account	$12.5k (50K) / $19.7k (150K)	Within 2 years; blown 3% / 0%
Value per account slot, 3 years	$34.8k (50K) / $52.8k (150K)	Net of all fees
Year-1 outlook (ramp to 20, mostly 150K)	~+$175k; ~$1.03M over 3 years	Backtest-based; ~$95k / $740k if live keeps 75% of the edge
Evaluation budget for the scale-up	~$20k set aside	Fees paid before payouts catch up; up to ~$35k if the edge is weaker
Cost of testing the edge live	~$400-800	If it fails, we stop after Phase 1
First payouts expected	~mid-to-late February 2027	Range: January to April+

Recommendation, in priority order. (1) **Prove the edge live**: accounts #1-#2 on **50K EOD** ($59 each), #3 as a **150K No-Activation** ($249) to test the 150K setup early; pass the live check (~40-70 trades at 75%+ of backtest). (2) **Scale Apex**: with ~$20k set aside for evaluation fees, add 150K No-Activation accounts two per week to 20. (3) **Open the personal account from the first payouts** (~$10k, around February), not from savings; per dollar, Apex evaluations earn far more in year 1 than a small personal account.

2. The strategy portfolio

Every strategy is automated in MultiCharts, trades Nasdaq-100 futures (MNQ) or crude oil (MCL), and is flat by 15:59 CT. Each was backtested 2018-2026 with realistic costs ($7.25 commission plus one tick of slippage per fill), confirmed trade-by-trade in MultiCharts, and ranked on a quality scale from S+ (best) to F.

Strategy	Idea in plain terms	Rank	Role
Overnight Bias ML	Trades the morning in the direction the overnight session leaned, filtered by a model	S	Biggest payout driver
Vault Break	Buys / sells breakouts of the day's 'noise band'; wins ~66% of trades	A	Engine of the evaluation; funded core
Bridge Monday Long	Holds a long from Sunday evening into Monday in uptrends	A	Uncorrelated Monday drift
Monday Long	Our own Monday long with a different trigger	A	Uncorrelated
Late-Day Flow	Follows strong moves into the last hour (ETF rebalancing flows)	A	Afternoon diversifier
Expiration Open Short	Short on monthly options-expiration mornings (dealer hedging)	A	Forced-flow event
CL Sunday Gap Fade	Fades crude oil's Sunday-open gap-ups (weekend overreaction)	A	Different market; cuts blow-ups
NFP Fade	Fades the jobs-report spike	B	Small, event-based

Why it should keep working. The strategies are built around repeatable market mechanics (overnight positioning, forced fund flows, options expiration, weekend gaps) rather than chart patterns. They have near-zero correlation with each other, and the combined plan is positive in both 2018-22 and 2023-26.

Quality controls applied to every strategy: realistic costs; random-direction placebo; results split by year and by long / short; multiple-testing correction (deflated Sharpe ratio); an independent re-implementation by a separate checker; and a regression showing the profit is not just market drift.

3. Funding model: Apex Trader Funding

An Apex account starts with an **evaluation**: reach a profit target within 30 days without breaching a trailing drawdown. Passing unlocks a **Performance Account (PA)** that pays out up to six times, then closes. A new evaluation replaces it. Up to 20 accounts can run at once.

Rule	50K account	150K account
Evaluation profit target	$3,000	$9,000
Max drawdown (end-of-day trailing)	$2,000	$4,000
Daily loss limit (pauses the day)	$1,000	$2,000
Max contracts	6 mini / 60 micro	12 mini / 120 micro
Payout ladder (6 payouts, then closes)	1,500 / 1,500 / 2,000 / 2,500 / 2,500 / 3,000 = $13,000	2,500 / 3,000 / 3,000 / 3,000 / 4,000 / 5,000 = $20,500
Payout conditions	5 days of $250+, balance $52,600+, 50% consistency	5 days of $350+, balance $154,600+, 50% consistency

Source: Apex pricing and rules pages (screenshots in the repository, October 15, 2026).

Choosing the account type

Each size comes with or without an activation fee. Trading rules and payouts are identical; only the cost differs. Because some evaluations fail, the real cost is: evaluation price x tries needed + activation fee.

Rank	Account type	Price	Cost per funded account	Net per slot over 3 years
1	150K No-Activation	$249	$598	$52,788
2	150K EOD, 5-pack	$199 + $150 activation	$628	$52,682
3	150K EOD, single	$219 + $150 activation	$676	$52,525
4	50K EOD, 5-pack (most cost-efficient)	$24.50 + $130 activation	$179	$34,813
5	50K No-Activation, 5-pack	$109	$218	$34,751
6	50K No-Activation, single	$119	$238	$34,690
7	50K EOD, single	$59 + $130 activation	$248	$34,604

- **Test phase:** single 50K EOD ($59 + $130 activation on a pass, ~$248 per funded account). The 5-pack is cheaper ($179) but all five evaluations start the day of purchase, so they trade identical days on the copier and pass or fail together: one bet placed five times. Singles keep accounts 5-10 trading days apart.
- **Scale phase:** 150K No-Activation. Each slot earns ~$18k more over 3 years; with a 20-account cap that is what counts.
- **Speed:** 50K reaches its first payout ~2 weeks sooner (median 87 vs 95 trading days); 150K pays ~50% more.
- Fees are only 2-4% of payouts on every path, so account size matters far more than the fee option.

4. Financial projections

Simulated on real market history (start dates 2018-2023, three-year windows), with every account running the plan through the exact Apex rules. These are backtest-based; Section 7 shows a weaker-edge case.

Single funded account

	50K (current sizing)	150K (plan x 1.5)
Payouts within 1 year	$10,184	$15,731
Payouts within 2 years	$12,450 (cap $13,000)	$19,743 (cap $20,500)
Accounts blown	3%	0%
All 6 payouts within 2 years	94%	91%

Three accounts: the first year month by month

After	Typical (median)	Bad case (10th pct)	Good case (90th pct)	Any payout received
1 month	-$400	-$520	-$250	1%
3 months	-$455	-$755	+$5,595	36%
6 months	+$4,045	-$705	+$19,385	71%
12 months	+$29,345	+$3,455	+$38,110	96%

Month 1 is fees only: evaluations pass in about 6 trading days, but Apex payouts need the balance built up first, so the first payout usually arrives in month 2-4.

Scaling to 20 accounts (cash after fees, median; real Apex prices)

Schedule	6 months	12 months	24 months	36 months	Bad case 12 m	Most cash outlay (bad case)
Recommended: first 3 slots 50K, each switching to 150K after its first funded account closes; +2 x 150K per week from month 2	$2k	$175k	$569k	$1.03M	-$8k	-$18.8k
All 20 slots 150K from the start	$5k	$194k	$591k	$1.04M	-$16k	-$22.6k
All 20 slots 50K	$11k	$152k	$390k	$672k	+$9k	-$5.7k
Recommended, if live keeps 75% of the edge	-$9k	$96k	$400k	$743k	-$33k	-$35.7k

150K accounts roughly double the 3-year total, but evaluation fees ($249 a try, ~2.4 tries per funded account) come before the payouts: set aside ~$20k, and pause new accounts if cumulative cash falls below -$20k. Cumulative cash reaches $100k after ~10 months (backtest edge) or ~12 months (75% edge).

Personal account (Phase 3 onward)

Without Apex's caps, the full plan at 1 NQ per strategy made about **$101k a year** in the backtest with a **$24k** maximum drawdown; full 1-NQ size needs about **$100k** (the drawdown is then ~24% of the account; $80k is the bare minimum). Start at 1/10 size (MNQ) with about **$10k from the first Apex payouts** and step up as the account grows: ~$25k = 1/4, ~$50k = 1/2, ~$100k = full size. At 1/10 size it earns only ~$10k a year in the backtest, which is why the Apex scale-up comes first.

5. Roadmap

Phase	Timing	Actions	Gate to move on
1. Prove	Now to ~week 8	#1 50K EOD (live since 10/12), #2 50K EOD Tue 10/20, #3 150K No-Activation ~10/27 (tests the 150K setup). Single evaluations, 5-10 trading days apart (5-pack evaluations all start at purchase). Weekly MultiCharts reports for live-vs-backtest tracking.	~40-70 live trades, live average at least 75% of backtest, no drift alarm
2. Scale	~Month 2-5	~$20k evaluation budget set aside. Add 150K No-Activation accounts, 2 per week, to 20 total. 50K slots keep cycling until their first funded account pays all 6 payouts ($13,000) or blows, then switch to 150K. Four copier masters (50K / 150K x evaluation / funded).	Live edge holds; cumulative cash above -$20k
3. Personal account	From the first payouts (~Feb 2027)	Open with ~$10k from Apex payouts (not savings); run the plan at 1/10 size (MNQ). Add Twin Continuation at small size (stop capped at 1 ATR). Step up size as the balance grows.	6-12 months of live results matching backtest
4. Grow	Month 6-12+	Personal account to full 1-NQ size (~$100k); promote live-confirmed strategies to S+; new strategies enter through the lifecycle below.	Ongoing monitoring

Strategy lifecycle (how new strategies are added)

Stage	Where	Gate
1. Research	Python backtest 2018-2026	Passes the multiple-testing bar, beats a random-direction placebo, positive in both 2018-22 and 2023-26
2. Confirmation	MultiCharts + independent checker	MultiCharts trades match the research version; checker passes it
3. Apex incubation	Smallest size, on accounts running the full plan	~40 live trades at 75%+ of backtest, no drift alarm, no rise in blow-ups
4. Live	Personal account	Sized so the worst drawdown is 20-30% of the account

Demotion: a first drift alarm halves the strategy's size; a second alarm or a live average below half the backtest sends it back to incubation or retirement.

6. Quality ranking and governance

Rank	Meaning
S+	Meets every S requirement and is confirmed in live trading (40+ live trades at 75%+ of backtest). Empty today; Overnight Bias ML is first in line.
S	Extreme profit and edge: ~$20k+ a year per NQ, t-stat 4.5+, profit factor 2+, 8 of 9 years positive, scalable.
A	Very strong: t 2.5+, profit factor 1.4+, 7+ of 9 years positive, MultiCharts-confirmed.
B / C	Real but smaller, or regime-dependent edges.
D / F	Weak after costs, or no edge. Over 200 ideas tested; most end here.

- **Live monitoring:** weekly reports feed a drift alarm per strategy (OK / WATCH / ALARM).
- **Operations:** an always-on machine (no sleep or forced updates), one copier master per account type and phase, and an error log of every MultiCharts issue solved.
- **Compliance:** every account runs the full plan on one symbol per market, so positions net within an account and never oppose each other across accounts (cross-account hedging is prohibited by Apex).

7. Risks and mitigations

Risk	What could happen	Mitigation
Backtest overstates the edge	Strategies were selected on the same history they are tested on; live results are typically lower	Phase-1 gate before scaling; multiple-testing correction; independent checker; drift alarm
Weaker live edge (75% case)	Year 1 ~$96k with the 150K ramp, but the bad case is about -$33k and up to ~$36k of fees go out before payouts	Scale only after the gate; ~$20k evaluation budget; pause new accounts below -$20k cumulative; half size on any ALARM
Correlated accounts	All accounts trade the same signals, so a bad month hits all of them together	Stagger account starts 5-10 trading days apart; gradual ramp
Prop-firm rule or payout changes	Apex can change prices, rules or payout timing	Diversify into the personal account; keep fees a small share of payouts
Operational failures	Disconnects, rejected orders, PC sleep (already seen in week 1)	One-account shakedown week, error log, always-on machine, weekly report checks
Personal capital at risk	Drawdowns in the personal account are real money	Start at 1/10 size with ~$10k; full size only after 6-12 months of confirmation
Event concentration	The CL fade earns ~85% of its profit on oil-news weekends	Small position (2 MCL); expected quiet stretches; watchlist review after each event

8. Immediate next steps

When	Action
Fri 10/16	Expiration Open Short trades on account #1: check fill, size and exit
Sun 10/18, 19:00 CT	Bridge Monday Long enters: confirm position and size on Monday morning
Tue 10/20	If both were clean, add account #2 (single 50K EOD, $59)
~Tue 10/27	Add account #3 as a 150K No-Activation ($249), with its own copier master and 150K settings
Every week	Export MultiCharts reports to the live/ folder for the live-vs-backtest check
~Mid-December	Phase-1 gate decision: scale with 150K No-Activation, or review
~Feb 2027	First payouts expected; open the personal account (~$10k) from them

Appendix: account settings

Account	Settings
50K evaluation	Vault Break 8 MNQ; Overnight Bias ADX30 risk $1,100; Bridge Monday 2 MNQ; Expiration Open Short risk $500
50K funded	Vault Break 3 MNQ (1 on flagged days); Overnight Bias ML risk $400; Monday Long 1; Expiration Open Short $700; Late-Day Flow 2; NFP Fade $500; Bridge Monday 1; CL fade 2 MCL. Full size once the cushion is $1,500, half size below
150K evaluation	Evaluation set x 2.5: Vault Break 20 MNQ; Overnight Bias ADX30 $2,750; Bridge Monday 5; Expiration Open Short $1,250
150K funded	Funded set x 1.5: Vault Break 4 (1 flagged); Overnight Bias ML $600; Monday Long 1; Expiration Open Short $1,050; Late-Day Flow 3; NFP Fade $750; Bridge Monday 1; CL fade 3 MCL. Full size from a $3,000 cushion

Disclaimer: all figures are historical backtests and simulations using Apex's published rules as of October 2026. They are estimates, not guarantees; futures trading involves substantial risk of loss.